



STRANGE BEDFELLOWS:
Nepalese prime minister
G.P. Koirala (left) with
Maoist leader Prachanda

Nepal's Maoists pushed the fragile democracy, established after the King was dethroned, to breaking point over electoral reforms but relented by the end of the year

With the politics of confrontation engulfing its neighbours India was asked to lend a helping hand and it did so with mixed success


MYANMAR OUT AFP PHOTO

SAFFRON REVOLT: (Left) Monks protest; (below) General Than Shwe


REUTERS/SUKREE SUKPLANG

In Myanmar the rebellion by Buddhist monks against the military junta was brutally repressed

two former prime ministers Benazir Bhutto and Nawaz Sharif, campaigned with gusto but just when it seemed that some semblance of democracy would be restored, Bhutto was assassinated on December 27. With Pakistan plunging into instability again, Delhi's concern over cross-border terrorism became deeper.

A surprising chill developed in India's relations with Russia that had nothing to do with the sub-zero temperatures in Moscow or one of the coldest winters in Delhi. Experiencing a major economic revival after rising oil prices brought in bountiful foreign exchange earnings, Russia began to assert itself. Apparently annoyed with India's growing tilt towards the US, the first signs of the Russians' displeasure became clear when External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee failed to secure a meeting with his counterpart Sergie Lavrov on his visit to Moscow in October. By then India had much to be unhappy about with the Russians unfairly doubling the price agreed upon for the sale of its aircraft carrier *Gorshkov*. Later, when Manmohan had a summit meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin, apart from irksome protocol issues over who should hold a banquet for him, Moscow made a whale of a fuss over India not inking an agreement to buy four more nuclear power reactors from it. When both BJP and the Left tried to use the issue as one more example of US bias, Manmohan had to specifically refute the charge in Parliament and explain that